

Sky is not the LIMIT

Civil Aviation Minister Patel set an election-eve record of sorts, attending 21 airport dedication functions in 16 days

For 16 days preceding March 2, Minister of State for Civil Aviation Praful Patel criss-crossed the country laying foundation stones for seven new airports and inaugurating 12 new terminals, including the domestic terminal in Delhi that won't be operational until April. February 20 was a particularly busy day for Patel who visited five cities to inaugurate or attend ceremonies relating to new airports. The day started at 9.30 a.m. with the ground-breaking ceremony for the new integrated terminal at the Chhatrapati Shivaji International Airport from where he moved to Indore where he inaugurated a new terminal following which he touched down in Bhopal at 1 p.m. Two hours later, he was in Raipur, 600 km away. Another inauguration and he was off to Ranchi, about an hour away as the jet flies.

The breathtaking rush was triggered not only by the need to beat the electoral code of conduct that came into effect with the announcement of polls but by the need to let voters know about the 'gigantic' strides in the sector during Patel's five-year tenure. It has seen proposals for seven Greenfield airports being granted approval, while another nine are under consideration of the Government. Projects completed included Tiruchirapalli, Bangalore, Visakhapatnam and Hyderabad airports while the Government has also approved modernisation and expansion of Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose International Airport at Kolkata (to be completed in February

2011) and Chennai Airport (to be completed by October 2010).

With 21 airports Patel has assiduously projected the aviation sector as a happening "sunrise sector that provide employment opportunity for the youth". In a document titled Vision 2020, the ministry hopes the country will have 500 operational airports. Currently, there are 448 airports, but only 80 are suitable for scheduled commer-



THOUGH NOT READY FOR OPERATIONS, THE DELHI AIRPORT WAS "INAUGURATED" TO BEAT THE POLL CODE DEADLINE

cial flights and the Airports Authority of India alone plans to spend over Rs 12,000 crore in the next five years on new and existing airports.

Considering that construction of airports was not a priority area for this *aam admi* friendly UPA Government, Patel needs to be lauded for his efforts to ensure that more Indians take to the skies and they will be able to do so from world class airports. But all things considered, Patel's 16-day-long bonanza is as bountiful as it gets.

by Nandini Vaish

Hyderabad, a thermal plant in Solapur and inaugurated an airport terminal in Srinagar. Minister for Chemicals, Fertilisers and Steel Ram Vilas Paswan inaugurated four ayurveda drug stores, launched with Congress MP Rahul Gandhi the rebuilding of a steel plant in Amethi, and inaugurated a public-sector steel processing plant at Bettiah in Bihar. Home Minister P. Chidambaram and Culture Minister Ambika Soni laid the foundation stone for a Bhagat Singh Memorial in Punjab; Labour Minister Oscar Fernandes laid the foundation stones for Employees State Insurance Corporation medical colleges.

The Government also brought out tackily-created advertisements with little recall value. While the

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Information and Broadcasting Ministry had itself issued print and audio visual advertisements worth about Rs 50 crore, departments like Rural Development and Civil Aviation went on with their full-page follies. The only glitch was in the Agriculture Ministry where the officials were not sure whether to carry Sonia's photograph, considering Agriculture Minister Sharad Pawar's strained relations with the Congress following seat-sharing talks in Maharashtra.

If project carrots and foundation stones can assure votes, the Congress can rest easy thinking it is on its way back to Raisina Hill. Experience, however, points to the contrary. ■